Group 6: Forecast and Foresight Report: Gort

Strategic Thinking Tools and Techniques

Students:

Ananya Mahadeva

Meeval Augustine

Torsa Mukhter

Wendy Lucio Perez

Olive Edeko

Lecturer: Theo Lynn

MSc in Business Analytics – DCU

Date: December 17th, 2025

Table of Contents

1. Executive Summary **4**
2. Introduction and Background **5**
2.1 Introduction 5
2.2 Background 5
3. Situation Analysis **6**
3.1 Geographic & Spatial Context 6
3.2 Demographic Profile 6
3.3 Socio-economic Profile 6
3.4 Vacancy and built environment 7
3.5 Community infrastructure 7
3.6 Digital Readiness Profile 8
3.7 PESTLE Analysis 9
3.8 Key Challenges 12
3.9 SWOT Analysis 13
4. Data and Methodology **15**
4.1 Sources and Data 15
4.2 Horizon Scanning 16
4.3 Driver Mapping 16
4.4 Axes of Uncertainty 17
4.5 Scenario Developing Method 18
5. Analysis **20**
5.1 Trends shaping Gort's Future 20
5.2 Understanding the dynamics of change 21
5.3 Identifying Critical Uncertainties 24
5.4 Developing Scenarios 26
5.5 Scenario 1 – Best-Case Scenario (2060): 27
5.6 Scenario 2 – Business-as-Usual Scenario (2060): 31
5.7 Scenario 3 – Worst-Case Scenario (2060): 35
5.8 Implications for Gort's Residents 39
5.9 Risks and Opportunities Across Scenarios 39
5.10 Implications for Policymakers 40
6. Strategic Recommendations **42**
7. Conclusions **43**
AI Declaration **44**
References **44**

Table of Figures

Figure 1. Driver Mapping Matrix for Gort 18
Figure 2. Axes of Uncertainty Framework 18
Figure 3. Scenario Matrix for Gort (2060) 19

1. Executive Summary

The purpose of this report is to explore the long term future of Gort, County Galway, through the application of foresight and forecasting techniques. This analysis utilises the techniques Horizon Scanning, Driver Mapping, Axes of Uncertainty, and Scenario Development to develop three scenarios applicable to Gort in the year 2060: A best-case, worst-case and business-as-usual scenario.

These techniques were developed by a situational analysis which provides key insights into Gort's current context.This analysis highlights several key strengths such a steady population growth, strong cultural diversity and key assets for potential growth such as the town's digital hub. Key challenges were also identified using this analysis, including high commercial and residential vacancy, limited local employment opportunities, low levels of digital adoption and constraints in the town's transport infrastructure.

Building on the situational analysis, the report then identifies factors such as key drivers and critical uncertainties shaping Gort's future. These factors are then used to develop the three aforementioned scenarios for Gort in the year 2060 and inform strategic recommendations, aimed at enhancing Gort's long-term resilience, competitiveness and quality of life.

2. Introduction and Background

2.1 Introduction

To develop this report, both Foresight and Forecast techniques were applied, as they're essential tools for decision-making in contexts of uncertainty. Foresight explores alternative future scenarios when multiple factors of uncertainty, disruption, and change are present. On the other hand, Forecasting uses historical data and trends to anticipate potential future outcomes. By combining both approaches, the future of the Gort, Co. Galway will be analysed up to the year 2060.

This report follows Pathway 5 of the Futures Toolkit, which focuses on exploring and communicating the complexity of a situation. Pathway 5 enables us to identify signals of change, map the drivers that influence the system, understand critical uncertainties and develop plausible scenarios that support strategic decision-making. Based on this framework, the analysis will consider data related to population, economy, digital economy, and society in general, as well as future-exploration techniques such as Horizon Scanning, Driver Mapping, Axes of Uncertainty, and Scenario Development to build the three alternative scenarios for Gort.

2.2 Background

Gort is a town located in Galway and is characterised by its agriculture, local commerce, and a growing multicultural population over the last two decades. However, recent studies reveal that it faces commercial and residential vacancy, low technology adoption and a lack of social, cultural, and youth infrastructure. On the other hand, it also presents major opportunities such as tourism potential, cultural diversity, increasing connectivity, and strong policy support for rural regeneration.

It is important to mention that documents such as Town Centre First and Our Rural Future emphasise the importance of revitalising urban centres through citizen participation, environmental sustainability, improved access to services and digitalisation.

Digitalisation plays a key role, as the Digital Town Blueprint highlights that although infrastructure and mobile connectivity are developing, digital adoption remains limited in key sectors such as Business, Tourism, Education, Civil Society and Public Services.

These factors represent the main uncertainties that will determine Gort's competitiveness and resilience towards 2060.

3. Situation Analysis

3.1 Geographic & Spatial Context

Gort is strategically located in South County Galway, regarded as a central point within Galway - Limerick/ Shannon Development Corridor. The town is characterised by its historic Georgian market structure and a compact urban form, with wide streets and footpaths that encourage walking and regeneration of the town. Gort is a rural catchment area with approximately 20,000 residents across Galway and Clare, which serves as a service center in terms employment, retail, education and community provision to the local area. Gort River is a natural asset for the town, recently enhanced by the development of a looped river walk. Despite these advantages, Gort has increased levels of residential and commercial vacancy, particularly in the town centre that can be developed for local residents. One of the main features of the town are heritage sites, including historic structures, and cultural landscapes, such as Coole Park and Thoor Ballylee, that form the strong spatial anchors.

3.2 Demographic Profile

Gort has constant population growth and significant cultural diversity. The population rate has increased by 5% from 2016 to 2022, currently there are 2,870 residents. Gort has more residents aged between 25-50, which represents families and working-age adults. Education patterns show that 16% of the population is educated and many of them are enrolled in post-secondary and further education. Gort is considered as one of the most ethically diverse small towns in Ireland, with one-third of the population being foreigners, including a broader Brazilian community. The town is very religiously diverse, with 30% of the population following a non-catholic religion or no religion (Local Government Ireland, 2025).

3.3 Socio-economic Profile

Gort's socio-economic profile demonstrates the town is strong from diverse perspectives, however, it also faces numerous challenges that impact resident's daily lives. Most of the people work in manufacturing industries or other manual and lower paid jobs. While few individuals work in professional or service oriented jobs compared with the other places in County Galway. For these reasons, the majority of residents face financial difficulties and unemployment rates are high. Other issues are the fact that many students drop out of school, young people find it hard to find jobs, and they have limited access to extracurricular

activities. Another major problem of the town is public transportation, residents find it hard to access education, training, and job opportunities outside of the town. Gort has a strong community, constantly growing cultural diversity, and an active young population that creates opportunities for the town to be socially and economically improved. Significant vacancy residential and commercial levels provide opportunities of regeneration, business developments, and developed local services (Urban Initiative, 2024).

3.4 Vacancy and built environment

Gort's built environment is represented by historic market towns and issues caused by long-term vacancy and under-used buildings. The town has many significant valuable heritage buildings, such as Georgian buildings and the Town Hall, which are not being properly used. Gort possesses numerous residential vacancies, many buildings are abandoned especially in the town centre. Therefore, it makes the centre feel less lively and residents prefer to live in other places. Another noticeable disadvantage is that Gort's commercial vacancy is 15.7%, considered as one of the most challenged towns in Galway to do business. The empty spaces of the town provide potential opportunities for regeneration, new housing, and creative workspaces for the community.

3.5 Community infrastructure

Gort is a town with a strong sense of community and has a wide range of community organisations that function with the aim of enriching the experiences of its inhabitants and visitors. However the community's infrastructure does not adequately support social cohesiveness or promote high quality of life.

The public transport network in Gort is limited for those dependent on it to access employment and facilities outside Gort. Cars are the dominant means of transport in Gort, making the town unattractive for pedestrians and cyclists. Yet, despite this dominance there are poor parking provisions in and around the town centre, reducing its accessibility.

Gort has near universal mobile broadband coverage but due to limitations in digital infrastructure this coverage displays variability in terms of data speed. Broadband speeds decrease as one moves out from the town centre, making connectivity an issue for many inhabitants.

Additionally there is a lack of accessible and affordable multi-functional community space to support extra curricular activities and the development of arts and cultural programmes. The lack of these activities and programmes often mean there isn't much in the town to engage people and results in residents feeling socially isolated.

To conclude, while there is a strong sense of community in the town, issues such as transport, digital connectivity and lack of facilities limit social interaction.

3.6 Digital Readiness Profile

Gort achieved a digital town score of 38/100, indicating that digital readiness is "ad hoc and mostly not documented".This suggests that digital infrastructure in the town is present but is not supported by a unified or strategic approach.

Gort has strong fixed broadband provision, with 100% fixed broadband coverage across its 644 premises. On the other hand, despite near universal mobile broadband coverage, this coverage displays variability across townlands in terms of speed, with data speed decreasing further out from the town centre. Though there is no municipal public Wi-Fi network and no free Wi-Fi at designated tourism sights, Gort does have free public Wi-Fi available in municipal buildings, retail outlets and hospitality premises. Notably 100% of Gort's listings on Tripadvisor offer free public Wi-Fi. Gort also has a connected digital hub with 9 desks available, however the absence of meeting rooms and additional co-working spaces limits its capacity to maximise the economic opportunity of remote work.

Digital adoption amongst local businesses is low. 55% of 175 businesses surveyed within a 2km radius of the town centre scored a 0 on the Web Technology Intensity Score (WTIS), indicating that over half the businesses have no online presence.

The opportunities to develop digital skills in Gort are limited. While there are some further education courses available, there are no digital education programmes available that are specifically tailored to young people or older residents, which creates barriers to digital inclusion.

3.7 PESTLE Analysis

Political

Gort's policy is mainly composed of regional and national development frameworks. Gort is a Town Centre First (TCF) town and therefore benefits from this national policy, launched in February 2022 that aims "tackle vacancy, combat dereliction and breathe new life into town centres" (Department of Housing, Local Government & Heritage, 2022). Our Rural Future is a national rural development initiative that aims to support improvement in job quality and career opportunities in job areas and also support the development of rural towns. These national initiatives create a supportive framework for enhancing both economic vitality and social wellbeing in Gort.

Regional and Local initiatives such as the Galway County Development Plan, the Gort Local Area Plan and the Gort Local Development Plan have objectives of promoting the creation of an attractive county to live, work, visit and enable businesses to flourish in an environment that offers a range of housing options, robust and diverse range of employment opportunities, access to quality infrastructure and community facilities with a high quality sustainable environment for all. However Gort is heavily reliant on public sector funding for major development projects.

As part of Project Ireland 2040, the Irish Government has committed to providing an additional €1 billion between 2019 and 2027 through the Rural Regeneration and Development Fund (RRDF), which supports job creation in rural areas, addresses rural depopulation, and funds regeneration and infrastructure improvements in towns and villages with populations of fewer than 10,000. To date, over €30 million has been allocated to projects in County Donegal under the RRDF (Donegal County Council, 2025). This strategic funding framework aligns with the objectives of the Regional Spatial and Economic Strategy (RSES) and can be leveraged by towns such as Gort to support compact growth and major development and regeneration projects.

Economic

There are several factors that challenge Gort's economic development, particularly in relation to employment structure in the town. Data from the 2016 census indicates that only 35.6% of employed residents living in Gort worked within the town, while 64.4% were employed elsewhere, highlighting a high level of daily commuting (Western Development Commission & CSO, 2016). Furthermore, the 2022 highlighted that small towns across the western region continue to experience significant outward commuting among their resident workforce (Western Development Commission, 2024; CSO, 2023).

As a result, a large proportion of Gort's population commutes daily for work, contributing to economic leakage as disposable income is spent outside the town rather than supporting the local economy. In addition, Gort's labour market is dominated by lower-paid sectors such as manufacturing and construction, with limited employment opportunities in sectors that provide high remuneration. This employment structure may contribute to youth outmigration and reduce the strength of the economy long-term, while rising housing prices and increasing rental costs place further pressure on the local economy.

At a rate of 15.7% the issue of commercial vacancy in Gort is notable. Additionally the residential vacancy & derelict rate stands at 5.6%. These unused assets have a negative impact on the economy but also represent opportunities for regeneration and entrepreneurship.

Underutilised assets such as associations with Yeats and Lady Gregory and natural amenities like the river and the Christ the King statue have potential to lead to increased tourism. The adoption of digital commerce under the Digital Towns initiative could further strengthen small business competitiveness and promote E-commerce.

Social

Gort is one of the most culturally diverse towns in Ireland, over one third of the population are non-Irish citizens. The strong presence of international residents paired with its sizable Brazilian population creates significant opportunities for cultural tourism.

Population growth of 5.4% between 2016 and 2022 reflect Gort as an attractive place to reside, however there is a strain on amenities and youth facilities. The unemployment rate stands at 11%, more than double the national average of 4%, furthermore school absenteeism is higher than the country-wide average of 3.9%.

There is a split in digital literacy within the town. Younger residents tend to be digitally adept while many older individuals and business owners lack digital skills, risking exclusion as more services shift online. Limited public transport leads to social isolation, restricting access to employment and facilities.

Technological

Technological factors in Gort present both challenges and opportunities for the town's development.

Gort benefits from efficient fixed broadband coverage, however inconsistent mobile broadband coverage leads to varying levels of data speed across the town, with speeds decreasing the further out one moves from the town centre. This variability limits reliable mobile connectivity for all residents and businesses and makes work practices such as remote work difficult in peripheral areas.

Public access to digital infrastructure is mixed. Gort does not have a municipal public Wi-Fi network or free Wi-Fi at designated tourism sites, which may affect the visitor experience and reduce time spent in the town centre. However, free Wi-Fi is widely available in municipal buildings, retail outlets, and hospitality premises, with all Tripadvisor-listed businesses offering free Wi-Fi.

The majority of businesses in Gort lack online presence, which limits competitiveness, and engagement of consumers. Additionally there is limited access to digital skills programmes, especially for young people and older residents.

Gort's digital hub, which currently has nine desk spaces, has potential to platform the growth of remote and hybrid working. However, the absence of meeting rooms and additional

co-working spaces restricts its capacity to function at its fullest potential. Expansion of this facility could help reduce outward commuting.

Legal

As Gort transitions towards being a Digital Town, compliance with data protection and privacy legislation is essential. Digital platforms, online services, and public-sector data collection all create legal obligations under national and EU frameworks such as GDPR.

Land ownership complexities in backland areas hinders further development of Gort with legal negotiations required before proceedings can occur. Additionally heritage buildings like the Town Hall and Market Town Hall incur legal protections that complicate development strategies.

Environmental

Reducing travel-related emissions and transitioning towards sustainable modes of transport is a key challenge for Gort, due to private cars being the dominant means of transport, making the town unattractive for pedestrians and cyclists. The encouragement of walking, cycling, and public transport can help reduce reliance on cars, however Gort's limited transport connectivity, especially for out-of-town transport, threatens the feasibility of this.

Derelict buildings decrease the town's visual appeal and also have the potential to pose environmental hazards due to structural deterioration and potential contamination. Additionally, energy-efficient design is increasingly important in refurbishment and newly developed buildings with Ireland's aim of achieving carbon neutrality by 2050.

3.8 Key Challenges

Gort faces a number of significant challenges. Employment opportunities in the town are limited, in comparison with the rest of Galyway fewer inhabitants are employed in key sectors such as agriculture, commerce, communications, public administration and

professional services. Instead employment is dominated by building and manufacturing sectors, which offer lower levels of remuneration. This contributes to residents seeking employment elsewhere and resulting in economic leakage from the town.

Gort's town centre experiences high levels of residential and commercial vacancy. Furthermore derelict buildings reduce the attractiveness of the town centre, reducing investment and time spent in these areas. Residential vacancy rates in Gort rates are double that of the state average.

Social challenges in Gort are exasperated by limited transport options and lack of designated spaces for community facilities and activities, contributing to social exclusion. There are limited facilities to meet the social needs of young people, simultaneously Gort has a higher level of school absenteeism than the state average of 3.9%.

Despite strong broadband provision, Gort's digital town score of 38/100 reflects an uncoordinated and largely undocumented approach to digital development, limiting business participation, digital inclusion, and the town's ability to fully leverage remote working opportunities.

The dominance of car centred transport reduces the town's attractiveness for pedestrians and cyclists, and affects progress towards more sustainable transport means.

Addressing these challenges is further constrained by the availability of funding, which remains a significant challenge in itself.

3.9 SWOT Analysis

Strengths

Gort has an ideal location in Galway, good connectivity and growing population that support local identity and social life. The town has a strong and active community, and a large young demographic that reinforce local identity and social life which supports community involvement and social network enhancement. The town has valuable natural resources, such as the river, Coole Park, and historical buildings that have potential to attract tourism. Wide

streets and central square are valuable assets for the community that create strong potential for future sustainable growth (Local Government Ireland, 2025)

Weaknesses

Gort lacks liveliness due to empty commercial and residential places that can be used for various purposes. Other problems are limited parking and inconsistent traffic patterns, which make it more difficult for residents to reach the town centre. The community doesn't have communal and multifunctional spaces for interacting with others, engaging young residents, and celebrating cultures. The town contains limited public transportation, which makes it harder for citizens to travel outside the town. Other issues include lack of extracurricular activities for young people and school attendance issues that make it harder for youth to learn and enjoy.

Opportunities

Providing more secured and communal areas for the community and young residents to socialise, practice sports, and participate in cultural activities would be beneficial to the entire society. Furthermore, increasing access to natural resources can attract tourism which would help the town's economy. Improving public In addition, public transport needs to be improved so that residents can easily reach the town centre for various activities (Urban Initiative, 2024).

Threats

Leadership and long term goals are needed to make the improvements in the town. If transportation issues, vacancy, and poor conditions of the streets aren't rectified, residents may become dissatisfied and decide to leave Gort, especially young residents.

4. Data and Methodology

4.1 Sources and Data

The analysis was based on the following quantitative and qualitative sources, which allowed us to understand Gort's current situation and trends, as well, the signals, drivers and uncertainties influence in alternative futures:

- **Gort Needs and Project Identification and Justification Report (2023):** This document contains the town's demographic profile, socioeconomic conditions, levels of commercial and residential vacancy, infrastructure and overall context.

- **Digital Town Blueprint-Gort (2023):** This document contains indicators of the town's digital adoption, including connectivity across sectors such as Business, Tourism, Civil Society, Education, and Public Services. It also includes national comparisons.

- **DFIN Demographics Paper:** Although not specific to Gort, this paper analyses national demographic trends, including changes in migration patterns, population growth, ageing, and cultural diversity, which are important characteristics for Gort's future.

- **Relevant National Policies:** Policies such as Town Centre First, Our Rural Future, The National Planning Framework, and The National Development Plan describe the policy environment that will influence the town's development. These policies help identify relevant factors such as digitalisation, urban regeneration, and sustainability.

Forecast and Foresight Methodology

We employed the UK Government's Futures Toolkit, specifically Pathway 5, as the methodological framework for this analysis. This pathway consists of the following four consecutive techniques: Horizon Scanning, Driver Mapping, Axes of uncertainty and Scenario Building.

4.2 Horizon Scanning

The Horizon Scanning is the process of looking for long-term trends, but it doesn't only focus on that.

In this report, this technique was applied to explore trends and weak signals that can influence Gort's future up to 2060. According to Futures Toolkit (Pathway 5), the outcome of this technique helps us to understand the potential future conditions and not to predict outcomes.

Main factors of change and uncertainties that either are already observable in the present (H2) or those developments that are focused on the signals in the long-term (H3) that can significantly change the future of the town were identified when applying this technique in our analysis. Further details of each one will be discussed in the 5.1 section.

4.3 Driver Mapping

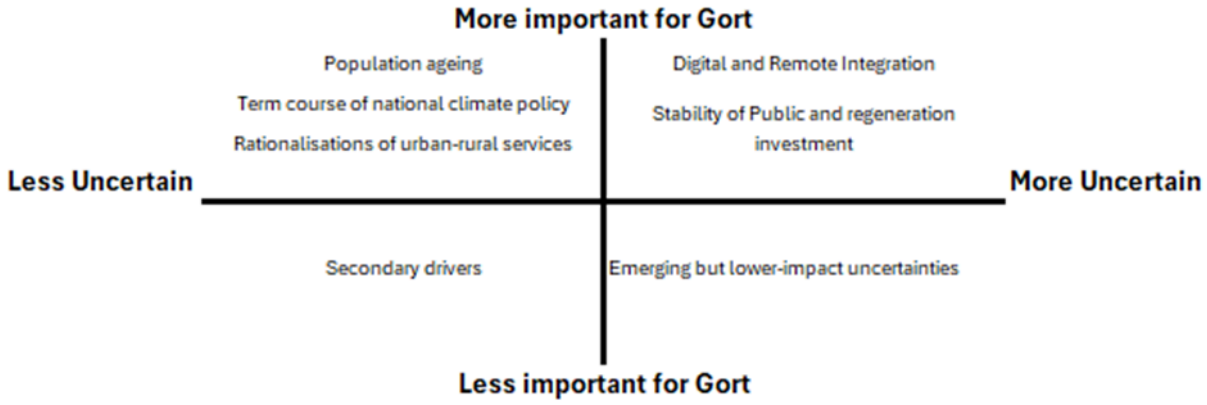
Once the main trends were identified in Horizon Scanning, we moved on to map the interactions among these factors in order to identify and organise the main categories that could affect Gort's future evolution.

After, the drivers were prioritised, based on the next dimensions, shaping Gort's long-term future:

- Level of uncertainty.
- Level of importance

The following figure illustrates a summary of the matrix that we built as a support tool in the development section 5.2 Understanding the dynamics of change for Gort; however, the report focuses on the main results, rather than on the positioning of each driver.

Figure 1. Driver Mapping Matrix



This importance-certainty logic supported an initial differentiation between those drivers who are relatively predictable and those who are more uncertain and potentially transformative.

4.4 Axes of Uncertainty

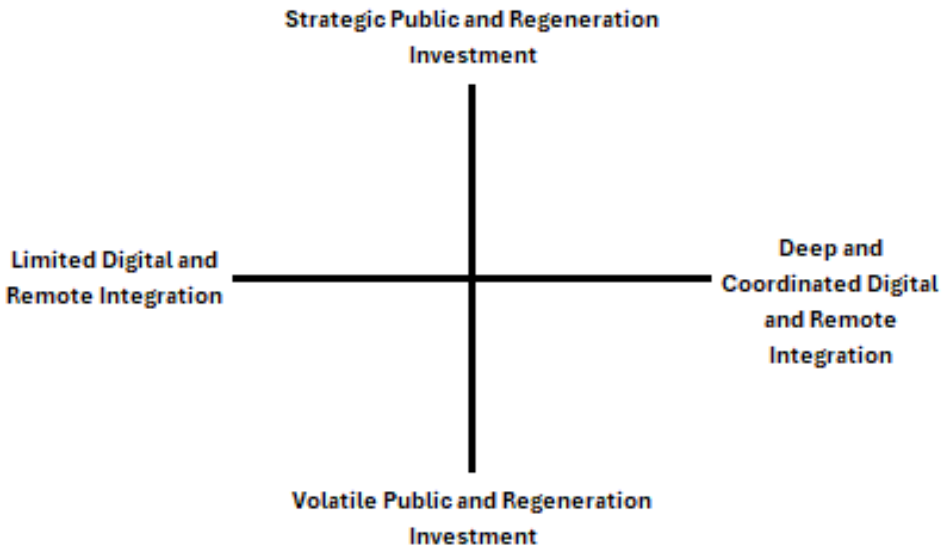
The Axes of Uncertainty technique was used to structure the scenario development phase, but just focusing on the most important drivers of uncertainty shaping Gort's long-term future.

According to the toolkit of the future, this phase builds upon the results of the previous mapping but now selects only those with high impact and uncertainty.

Each axis represents a continuous range between contrasting, yet plausible, conditions. Furthermore, the axes must be independent of each other, meaning that one doesn't determine the other, but both can interact. This allows for the exploration of multiple scenarios.

For illustrative purposes, the following figure shows the result of applying this technique in the analysis performed in section 5.3. Change Drivers.

Figure 2. Axes of Uncertainty



Using this technique, the analytical bases for selecting scenarios in the next phase were obtained

4.5 Scenario Developing Method

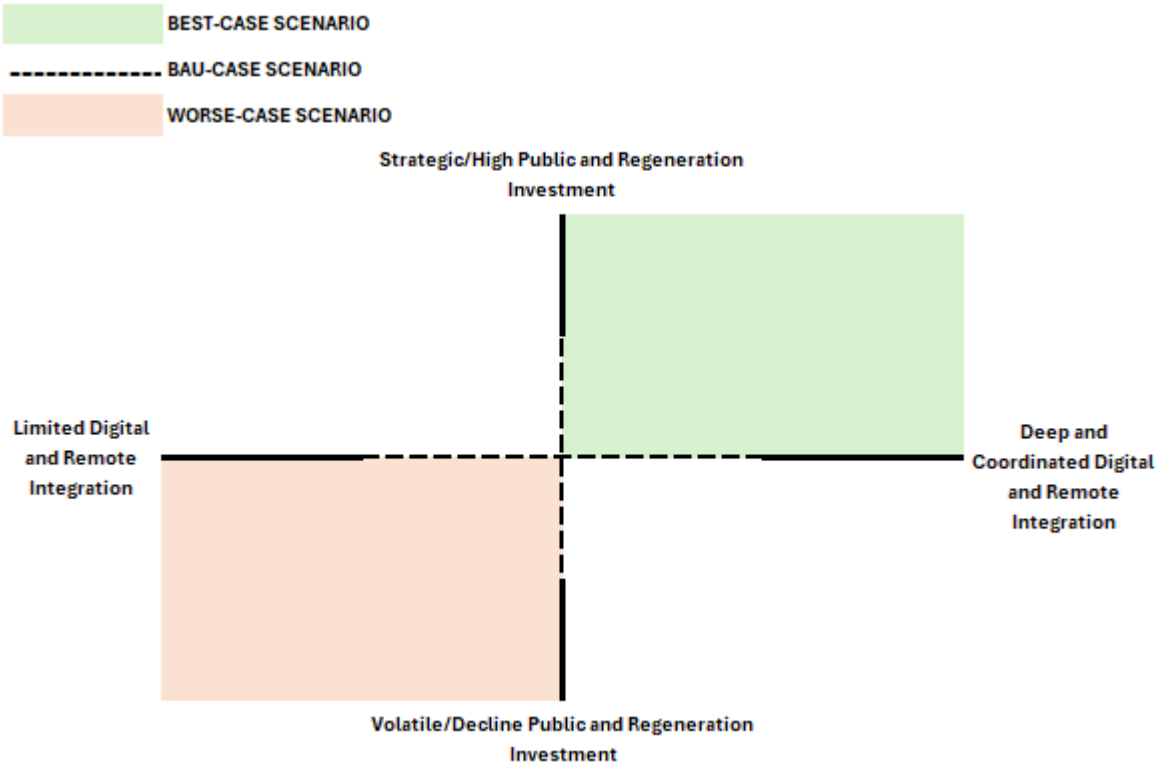
This phase focuses on exploring and communicating the complexity of a system rather than predicting a single outcome. The method allows for the construction of multiple plausible scenarios based on the interactions of the key uncertainties identified in the previous phases.
As mentioned earlier, two critical uncertainties were selected based on their systemic influence and long-term uncertainty:

- Digital and Remote-Work Integration
- Stability of Public and Regeneration Investment

Together, these two axes create a two-dimensional framework that generates a variety of plausible future conditions for Gort. Once the four quadrants were established, three scenarios were developed to represent the different and significant future trajectories.

As an illustrative explanation the three scenarios could be identified in the following figure.

Figure 3. Scenario Matrix for Gort



Best-Case Scenario: representing strategic or high digital integration and remote work, combined with stable and coordinated public investment.

Business-As-Usual Scenario: representing ongoing existing dynamics, where challenges are partially addressed without achieving systemic transformation.

Worse-Case Scenario: representing limited digital integration and unstable or declining public investment.

Each scenario considered various combinations of uncertainties that would influence the key dimensions for Gort's future, including employment, economic activity, population and migration patterns, job and housing vacancies, service provision, and overall quality of life.

5. Analysis

5.1 Trends shaping Gort's Future

The next table summarises the key trends found during the exploration of factors shaping future conditions of Gort:

EMERGING TREND	DESCRIPTION	TIME	RELEVANCE
Limited youth and increased demand for community hubs	The community has limited recreational opportunities for young people and few arts and cultural venues.	H3 (long-term)	Without investment, lack of socialisation, and youth disengagement, it may increase vacancy.
High residence and commercial vacancy.	The vacancy shows a low contribution to the local economic activity.	H2 (medium-term)	Low local spending can cause an economic flatline.
Remote and hybrid work.	New ways of work enable higher paying jobs from lower cost locations.	H3 (long-term)	Influences the local economy by population retention.
Increasing awareness of Low-Carbon and Climate–Resilence	Governments are increasingly focused on greener inspired lifestyles.	H3 (long-term)	A prioritisation of sustainability will contribute with a reduction of environmental footprint enhancing the ecological well-being.

Increasing youthful population.	Higher proportion of young people and working age residents.	H3 (long-term)	Increasing pressure on education and recreational spaces that influence long-term labour supply and service demand.
Increasing cultural diversity triggered by migration.	More than 30% of residents are non Irish.	H3 (long-term)	Changes on community dynamics
Low digital adoption across different sectors.	Low levels of digital readiness across public services, education, civil society and tourism.	H3 (long-term)	Shapes access to services and work.
Fragmented digital governance	Limited coordination of digital initiatives	H3 (long-term)	It can provoke limited participation

Overall, Horizon Scanning indicates that Gort's future will be influenced by the interaction of digital integration, investment continuity, demographic change, town-centre dynamics, and climate pressures. These insights informed the prioritisation of key drivers in the subsequent analysis.

5.2 Understanding the dynamics of change

A diverse range of developments across political, economic, social, technological and environmental fields were identified through the horizon scanning exercise. According to the Driver Mapping, we can identify how these drivers interact and their significance and level of confidence.

Digitalisation and Remote Work

Digitalisation and working from home is a big potential driver. Gort has relatively strong digital connectivity but 'horizon scans' show that transformation isn't necessarily going to happen just because you have infrastructure. Actual results may differ materially from those in the estimates due to unknown variables that are quite volatile, including digital literacy, institutional adoption and cultural embrace of remote work.Effective integration could support employment diversification and population retention, while uneven adoption risks increasing inequality.

Policy Cycles and Public Investment

Another major driving force behind public investment is Stability in it.Even though Gort is referred to in regeneration plans and climate strategies, it still remains unclear as to how such activity will be funded over the long term and organised. Although a long-term rejuvenation of town-centre land wholesale renovation in terms of housing and the accompanying social services, and whole system adjustment at city level are different in time scales project managed funds have to be used for both purposes.

Migration and Demographic Trends

The trend of an aging population, immigrant cardinality also may small-beam than population immigrants, but whether it is possible. A flow of external in-migrants attracted by better safety, lower cost of living and proximity to major health facilities might balance out other exits but that depends on the availability of housing; other necessary inputs such employment access and service provision. Demographic changes are therefore closely tied to the digitalisation and investment in the community.

Town Centre Dynamics and Housing

The quality of the public realm, vacancy levels and underutilised commercial space affect the vitality of the town-centre. Retail and service delivery changes and structural changes create uncertainty, whereas housing supply and affordability could limit growth in the future,

especially in case remote work demand grows before equivalent investment is made in refurbishment.

Climate Transition and Environmental Resilience

One of the contextual forces is climate transition which is gaining significance. Although the direction of the national policy is clear, it isn't known what will happen on the ground and what adaptive capacity will be. In the case of Gort, climate resilience is significantly associated with long-term planning and the sustainability of public investment.

The drivers were assessed based on the extent of uncertainty surrounding the evolution of the drivers to 2060 and the ability to alter Gort long term development path materially.

Prioritisation: Impact vs Uncertainty

Drivers which were deemed to have significant effect but were fairly predictable were classified as predefined trends. Among them were:

- Population ageing
- The long-term national policy on climate.
- On-going rationalisation of urban-rural services.

On the other hand, drivers with high importance and uncertainty were classified as prioritised drivers, those were:

Digital and Remote Work Integration

Gort has a rather strong digital infrastructure but its successful implementation into the local economy is questionable. Digital skills, organisational adoption, local business participation and more general labour-market factors determine the outcomes. The impacts of this driver are extensive to employment, population retention, housing demand, and local expenditure.

Stability of public and regeneration investments

The development path of Gort has to be inherently connected with the government investments in redevelopment, housing and infrastructure. In as much as there are policy frameworks, long term continuity of financing and strategic coordination is always unpredictable in the long run. This driver directly affects the town centre vitality, capacity to adapt to climate and confidence in investing privately.

5.3 Identifying Critical Uncertainties

Change drivers refer to critical uncertainties, which are both strong and uncertain in the long-term development.

According to the driver mapping and prioritisation tool developed in Section 5.2, two drivers were selected as the most influential to these criteria, namely the success of digital and remote work integration, and the stability of public and regeneration investment. These aspects were termed as significant uncertainties due to the fact that their future cannot be predicted, their implications are systemic and their combination will result in radically different Gort development pathways by the year 2060.

Critical Uncertainty 1: Digital and Remote-Work Integration

The question in this matter concerns the degree of the successful realisation of digital infrastructure, skills, and organisational practices in the local economy and community of Gort.

On one extreme of the spectrum, there is digital infrastructure, which is not fully used. The possibility of having remote jobs is not evenly spread, no digital gaps are closed yet, and local enterprises are not good at incorporating digital technologies into their routine. Digitisation in this environment benefits the economy and population in a narrow way.

Conversely, digital and remote work are closely and harmoniously tied up. Digital skills are no longer exclusive to any single age group, working remotely is a standard practice in most sectors, and digital technologies are actively used by local businesses and services. In this scenario, digitisation enhances job diversification, population retention and local economic development.

This doubt is fundamental as digital and distance working has a direct effect on the provision of employment, migration, housing requirements, and sustainability of rural communities in the long-term.

Critical Uncertainty 2: Stability of Public and Regeneration Investment

The second major uncertainty is the continued and strategic integration of government investment in Gort so as to help in rural development, regeneration and climate adjustment.

At one extreme of the range, the regeneration and public investment is erratic or falling. There is no long-term planning as short-term, a patchwork funding is inadequate and therefore there is underinvestment in the town centre renovation, housing refurbishment, and climate resilience.

At the other part of the spectrum, investment is predictable, regular and strategic in policy areas. The long-term financial sustainability facilitates the coordinated regeneration plans, improves the quality of the public realm, encourages the renovation of housing, and increases the trust in the investment of the private and community-based investment.

This uncertainty is vital since the physical infrastructure, delivery of services and the capacity of the rural towns to react to structural change is supported by public investment.

Construction of the Axes of Uncertainty

The two critical uncertainties that were joined together created the axes of uncertainty framework. All the uncertainties were represented in terms of a range between two opposing, but possible states, not as a binary or value judgement.

- The horizontal axis shows the Effectiveness of Digital and Remote-Work Integration, with less and disproportionally integrated to the more profound and integrated integration.
- The vertical axis shows the Stability of Public and Regeneration Investment, which is volatile or decreasing investment to the sustained and strategic investment.

The two axes are analytically independent: none of them determines the other. Nevertheless, they are engaged in practice, which influences the circumstances in which economic activity,

population changes, and place-based development takes place. The combination of these determines a plausible future environment of Gort.

5.4 Developing Scenarios

The scenario matrix is developed based on the axis of uncertainty and the UK Government's future toolkit. It illustrates how several combinations of uncertain circumstances could influence Gort's journey until 2060.

The matrix combines two critical uncertainties:

- Effectiveness of digital and remote-work integration
- Stability of public and regeneration investment

Four theoretical quadrants are produced by these axes, and the following three scenarios are interpreted:

- **Best-Case:** High digital integration, stable and coordinated investment
- **Business-as-Usual:** Moderate digital integration, uneven investment continuity (intermediate position in the matrix)
- **Worst-Case:** Limited digital integration, volatile or declining investment

Each cell in the matrix emerges as a different configuration of:

- Employment and economic activity
- Population and migration patterns
- Town-centre vitality and housing
- Service provision and quality of life

5.5 Scenario 1 – Best-Case Scenario (2060):

Overview

In this best-case scenario, Gort successfully uses digital technology and long-term public investment to strengthen its local economy and improve quality of life. Strong co-ordination between local government, national programmes and community organisations is what propels progress in this scenario. Instead of relying on short-term projects, Gort uses a clear, long-term plan that links housing, social infrastructure, regeneration, and digital growth.

The two key changes that make this future possible are.

1. Improved local governance makes it possible to apply national financial programs like Town Centre First and the Rural Regeneration and Development Fund (RRDF) in a coordinated manner.
2. Digital technology is viewed as a tool that promotes employment, services, education, and community life rather than merely as infrastructure.

Digital Transformation in Everyday Life

As of 2060, Gort has people of all ages with digital capabilities. Most local businesses now have a website rather than relying solely on a traditional shopfront queue. Credits to training and support programs provided by the local government. The use of digital technology is helping the public sector, tourism, and education improve the service quality and the ease of access to the services offered.

Due to the increase in remote working, many businesses are now operating remotely in Gort. The establishment of a digital hub in Gort provides meeting rooms and shared office space that encourages entrepreneurs and remote workers to relocate to the area. Online sales and digital services also provide local companies with an opportunity to generate additional revenue, thus increasing the flexibility and resilience of the local economy (Our Rural Future: Rural Development Policy 2021-2025).

Strategic and Sustained Public Investment

This public expenditure will enable the completion of projects supported and planned by national initiatives like the RRDF and Town Centre First. Housing, public areas, and regeneration are done under one clear plan.

Local and regional organisations cooperate for faster work, which encourages private investors to invest alongside public funding.

Economic Change and Local Jobs

Local employment greatly improves by 2060. In contrast to contemporary trends where people travel to other places for employment, the majority of the locals work locally. By 2030, new enterprises will have been founded and they will continue to flourish in the tourism, digital services and creative industries.
Commercial buildings and vacant houses are renovated and put to new uses. Commercial vacancy falls to less than 10%, while residential vacancy falls to less than 2%. The town centre is vibrant and appealing. Due to improved employment prospects and a more varied local economy, average household income increases by 25–30% from 2025 levels. More individuals relocate to or remain in Gort as employment grows.

Population, Community and Inclusion

Future populations are up from the past. Young people will continue to remain in Gort, and many enjoy being part of the community. The town continues to grow approximately 2-3 percent each year, which supports schools, healthcare and community services.

Gort's different cultures are seen as a strength, and the local council supports community events and activities.

Social Infrastructure and Quality of Life

The growth of the economy will coincide with the growth of investments in social infrastructure. More people are using public transport instead of cars. New creative spaces like co-working spaces, youth centres, cultural venues provide opportunities to work together and stay active throughout life.

In addition, digital inclusion programs are ensuring that seniors and other vulnerable groups have access to technology so that they don't get left behind. The combination of improved

physical conditions and new mixed-income housing developments has resulted in a decrease in school absenteeism and an increase in youth participation in schools, as well as an improvement in housing quality. Together, these factors, combined with a high level of community engagement, better environmental conditions and easier access to services, have allowed Gort to provide residents with a high quality of life.

A Revitalised Town Centre

The town centre is the focal point for all aspects of everyday life. Houses, shops, culture, and office space are located in historic buildings that have been refurbished and repurposed for modern purposes. Shopfronts for all local businesses, increased options for non-motorised transportation and local festival opportunities/recurring events have contributed to creating a more pedestrian-friendly environment, allowing people to remain within the limits of the town.

Tourism focuses on local, authentic experiences linked to the town's history and culture, which is helping both residents and visitors use the town centre as a lively meeting place.

Risks and Policy Timing

While there is great hope for our future, there are still serious risks ahead. Some people may struggle to access training or adapt to digital jobs, and small businesses find it difficult to move their work online. These challenges show inclusive policies and targeted support are needed.

The most important time period is between 2025 and 2035. Decisions made during this timeframe regarding planning, skills and governance will have long-lasting consequences. Delaying or postponing the implementation of these decisions increases the chance for a prolonged downturn and significant loss of opportunities. Conversely, when early implementation takes place, there is increased potential for rapid growth.

Key Event Timescale (2025-2060)

- **2025-2027** - Development of local government reform and creation of cross-agency partnerships for coordinated funding and planning. Launch of a digital skills development strategy and funding for the development of digital skills.

- **2027-2032** - Establishment and growth of digital hub. Arrival of the first wave of remote workers and small digital enterprises. Establishment of Town Centre First Projects.
- **2032-2037** - Completion of major town centre regeneration projects. Beginning of significant decrease in commercial and residential vacancy rates.
- **2037-2045** – Continuing Investment in Housing, Social Infrastructure, and Public Transport. Growth in Household Incomes; Development of Stronger Cultural Identity.
- **2045-2060** - Recognition of Gort as a nationally recognised rural, resilient and connected community with strong community life, diverse employment opportunities and high quality of life.

Implications for Policymakers

This scenario shows that successful rural development depends on more than infrastructure spending. Long-term success comes from strong governance, coordinated investment and inclusive digital development. Early, well-planned action greatly increases the chances that Gort becomes a resilient, vibrant and attractive town by 2060.

5.6 Scenario 2 – Business-as-Usual Scenario (2060):

Overview

In this business-as-usual scenario, Gort avoids major decline but doesn't achieve significant transformation. Development continues in a slow and uneven way, shaped by short-term funding cycles, partial digital adoption and limited coordination between local and national stakeholders (Town Centre First, 2023). While some improvements occur, they're not strong enough to address long-standing structural challenges such as vacancy, youth out-migration and limited local employment opportunities.

Progress in this scenario reflects a continuation of current trends rather than a clear strategic shift.

Digital Development: Partial and Uneven

By 2060, Digital infrastructure has developed in Gort, but there is still inconsistency in digital adoption. Although most businesses have some form of online usage, less than 50% of businesses are utilising technology to expand their businesses or improve their productivity. Digital skills training exists, but people are only using the training at different levels depending on their age and job type.

There is some form of remote employment, but it is still very limited. About 20-25% of people work from home or have a job that uses technology for the majority of their tasks. These positions are generally occupied by better-educated people and people employed by employers outside of Gort. Gort does have a digital hub and is still considered very small and has limited capacity for outreach. This means that while access to services has become easier and more convenient through the use of digital technologies, they haven't fundamentally changed the economic conditions of Gort.

Public Investment: Short-Term and Fragmented

Public investment is still active from the national programmes like Town Centre First and RRDF. However, investment is mainly short-term and focused on projects. Regeneration projects have been implemented in isolation rather than as part of an overall strategy for

sustainable development. Some buildings have been refurbished, and there is improvement in public spaces. However, the regeneration of the town overall is a slow, uneven process.

There is a lack of coordination between departments and agencies, from which many opportunities are lost. State-sponsored digital governance structures are not fully established, and outcomes aren't consistently monitored. There remains a level of caution from the private sector regarding investment in the town, as they typically respond only to specific, immediate opportunities rather than being influenced by the longer-term potential of the town's development.

Economic Conditions and Employment

Local employment in Gort has seen modest improvement over the past few years, with only 40-42% of residents working locally by 2060. Many residents continue to commute or work for an employer outside of Gort. New businesses start sporadically in the retail, tourism and small service industries but remain modestly growing in the digital and creative sectors. Vacancy rates continue to decline at a slow pace, with an average residential vacancy rate of about 4-5% and an average commercial vacancy rate of approximately 12-14%. While some areas of Gort's town centre appear to be more vibrant than others, other areas remain challenged. While Gort's household income has grown over a period, it has kept pace with inflation. This situation creates a stable but fragile equilibrium. Gort is functioning but lacks the momentum and resilience to create greater levels of transformation.

Population and Community Trends

The population in Gort has remained relatively stable with slow growth every year. Continued out-migration among the youth is also evident. There has been a slight reduction in this trend as many young people return later in life due to housing costs. The cultural diversity of Gort has continued to be a defining characteristic of Gort. Community organisations will continue to play an important role in Gort, but there is a lack of limited funding and planning. The ability of community organisations to reach long-term goals is diminished. Although educational outcomes have gradually been improving, there remains a weak link between education and employment within Gort.

Social Infrastructure and Quality of Life

Social infrastructure development is progressing slowly. While some improvements to community infrastructure have taken place, there are still large gaps in many areas, including cultural facilities, youth service delivery and services for shared working environments. Public transport options are showing some slight signs of improvement but there is still a reliance on privately owned vehicles.

Digital inclusion makes up for a lack of access to the internet for various areas throughout Gort. However, the majority of the population doesn't have access, especially those who are low-income or are elderly. While overall quality of life is acceptable, there are still large differences between neighbourhoods and the social status of each group.

Town Centre Experience

The state of the town center is a mixed bag. Several historical buildings are being refurbished and reused, but some are still vacant and are not fully used. Some pedestrian route improvements have been made. The scale of tourism and culture-related events remains small and provides a platform to help define local identity but doesn't produce any significant impacts on local economic development. Overall, while the Town Centre can adequately serve its function, it still hasn't regained its prior position as a vibrant Town Centre as expected.

Risks and Missed Opportunities

The risks here represent missed opportunities for local policymakers to capitalise on this potential for future economic growth. The gradual stagnation of Gort, due to a lack of leadership and a long-term perspective, puts Gort at risk of investment opportunities.

Missed opportunities in this scenario can be found in the timeframe from 2025 to 2035, when there exists an opportunity to strengthen governance, develop digital skills and improve vacant space usage, which is all evidenced through the land use and footprint of Gort.

Timeline of Key Events:

- **2025–2030:** Beginnings of coordination efforts, many delayed. Some sporadic regeneration and digital skills projects were initiated, but they were limited in their scope and reach.

- **2030–2035:** Several buildings in the town centre have been renovated, but many continue to be underutilised. The opening of the digital hub was successful in reaching a certain capacity. Continued out-migration of the local youth population.
- **2035–2045:** Overall increase in the level of public service and vacant property, but no major changes to the overall population.
- **2045–2055:** Gort has remained stable.The local economy has yet to return to a flourishing state, while the standard of living for residents is fine, Local neighbourhoods have different inequality levels.
- **2055–2060:** Gort has reached a very low-growth equilibrium. The viability of local governments and services will be more challenged.

Implications for Policymakers

Evidence indicates persistence by preventing decline, but it will not guarantee long-term existence. Incremental advancement provides the continuity required to support minimum standards; however, if there is no coordinated initiative and a sustained long-term commitment to the support of continual coordination, the structural challenges don't disappear. To achieve better results, policymakers must implement and dedicate resources to improving governance capacity, building skills, and developing comprehensive regeneration strategies. (The Futures Toolkit: Tools for Futures Thinking and Foresight Across UK Government Resource)

5.7 Scenario 3 – Worst-Case Scenario (2060):

Overview

In this worst-case future, Gort experiences a slow but persistent decline. Rather than being caused by a single crisis, this outcome results from continued weak governance, limited investment and failure to adapt to economic and digital change. National policies exist, but Gort is unable to benefit fully due to poor coordination, short-term planning and limited local capacity (Gort Town Plan, 2024). Over time, missed opportunities accumulate, reducing resilience and quality of life.

Digital Exclusion and Missed Transformation

The existing digital infrastructure in Gort will be used for digital services, but the majority of the population do not have access to digital skills. Although many businesses in the area do have a basic online presence, over 75% of local businesses do not actively engage with their customers online, and there are limited programmes within the community to provide training. Many older residents, low-income families and small businesses within Gort do not have access to digital skills, and it becomes increasingly disconnected from the economic and social opportunities available through digital platforms and services.

Remote work is hardly encouraged, and due to lack of funding, the digital hub will either close or operate at a minimal capacity. As the digital economy has continued to evolve, public services, tourism and education are all struggling to keep up with the expanding digital delivery models, creating additional barriers for individuals who wish to access these services and reinforcing social exclusion within this community. Gort will become increasingly less competitive and desirable as a place to live and invest.

Weak and Unreliable Public Investment

In this scenario, public investments are inconsistent and reactive. Funding from programs like Town Centre First and the RRDF is random and often lost to competing towns that have a stronger capacity for governance. As such, most projects are of a small nature and poorly connected, which therefore limits their impact over time.

There is a lack of coordination between local, regional and national entities, which results in duplicated efforts, delays in delivery and under-delivery. As there are no established digital governance structures, monitoring of project outcomes is inadequate. Private investors view this uncertainty as a financial risk and therefore largely choose not to invest in the town, thereby continuing to create a dependence on limited public financing.

Economic Decline and Employment Loss

The town will lose over 70% of its total workforce by 2060. Commuting will become necessary for almost all employed residents. The number of business closures each year will continue to outweigh newly opened businesses, especially within retail and service sectors. The local economy will rely heavily on only a few industries and, therefore, will remain extremely susceptible to outside events that could negatively impact the area.

On top of this, residential and commercial vacancies will continue to increase dramatically. By 2040, there will be an increase in residential and commercial vacancies. Again, these types of situations contribute to an overall feeling of neglect and decay within the community, and by 2060, household incomes will continue to decline in real value when compared to their value during 2025, resulting in increased financial strain on the residents.

Population Loss and Social Strain

As mentioned previously, these trends are part of a cycle of negative feedback. Loss of jobs leads to an exodus of the population, which causes the area to become less attractive to potential businesses or services, leading to fewer job opportunities, leading to an ever-increasing population decrease. The cycle continues, as each declining indicator makes it increasingly more difficult for the community to recover from declining economies.

Young people continue to leave for education and jobs and will likely not return after completing either of these pursuits. This ultimately leads to an ageing population and a declining number of people in the working-age population.

The loss of cultural diversity, once viewed as a potential asset to the community, is viewed as an increasing source of stress and tension as the means of socialising become increasingly weaker. Community organisations continue to struggle to stay afloat due to a lack of both financial resources and community volunteer fatigue. Over the years, as more young people

drop out of high school and school-to-work links become weaker, educational outcomes have worsened. Young people, low-skilled workers and small businesses will continue to be challenged in this environment as job and business opportunities become more concentrated outside the community.

Erosion of Social Infrastructure and Quality of Life

The deterioration of social and physical infrastructures has an impact over time. The reduction of public transportation options has created a greater dependency upon the automobile for individuals able to afford one, while an increase in isolation exists for individuals unable to access private transportation. Facilities that cater to the community are either closed or operating on a limited schedule, with youth and cultural services suffering most.

In addition, an increase in digital exclusion among older residents and low-income families has resulted in increased social isolation. The quality of the housing stock has diminished due to slow maintenance and refurbishment and an increase in derelict properties. Therefore, the overall quality of life within Gort has decreased substantially with an increase in social isolation, decreased access to services, and increasing levels of pessimism surrounding the future.

A Hollowed-Out Town Centre

The town center's social and economic significance will diminish significantly by 2060. The vast majority of heritage buildings in the town center will be unoccupied or in a state of continued disrepair throughout the decade. Minimal pedestrian activity and declining retail businesses reduce opportunities for reinvestment in the area. Poorly maintained public areas create unsafe and unattractive environments.

Tourism in the town center will continue to decline due to Gort’s inability to define or create its own distinct identity or adequately preserve its cultural and heritage assets. As a result, the town center will increasingly be seen as merely a transitional area or a place to pass through, rather than a destination for residents or visitors to spend time and enjoy.

Risks, Lock-In Effects and Missed Policy Windows

The principal risk associated with this future scenario is long-term lock-in. By failing to respond effectively to the townspeople's concerns regarding the degradation of the town center during the period of 2025-2035, the town will ultimately limit its future opportunities because of ever-increasing costs associated with restoring a declining area.

Trust in the local government and community decreases. As more residents leave the area, there will be fewer people around to support existing businesses in a variety of ways. As such, there will be no incentive for institutions or other organisations with invested interests in Gort to make any financial investments into the area.

Once the cycle of decline is established, it becomes increasingly difficult and more costly for institutions or communities to develop momentum to revitalize the area.

Timeline of Key Events:

- **2025–2030:** Governance responses are inadequate, and regeneration efforts fail to attract support. Digital adoption stagnates, and skills shortages become greater as younger individuals migrate in higher numbers.
- **2030–2035:** Commercial and residential vacancies spike dramatically. The closure of major businesses takes place, and many community organisations struggle to maintain themselves. The critical period for intervention has passed.
- **2035–2045**: Decline in population becomes evident. Public services struggle to provide adequate levels of service. Physical deterioration of infrastructure increases rapidly.
- **2045–2055**: Gort goes into a prolonged state of decline, with heritage buildings suffering severe deterioration and few prospects for reinvestment. Out-migration becomes common.
- **2055–2060:** The town becomes increasingly remote, and recovery will be economically prohibitive. It remains locked into low equilibrium, with limited economic activity and decreasing quality of life.

Implications for Policymakers

This scenario highlights the consequences of inaction and fragmented governance. Without early, coordinated intervention, Gort risks entering a downward spiral that is difficult to reverse. Policymakers seeking to avoid this outcome must prioritise governance capacity, inclusive digital skills, and integrated regeneration strategies. Preventing decline is far less costly than attempting recovery after long-term damage has occurred.

5.8 Implications for Gort's Residents

All three future scenarios present very different patterns of quality of life for residents. If governance, digital development and investment are managed effectively, residents in Gort will benefit from better job opportunities, service access, a stronger community and a revitalised town centre. In contrast, the more negative future scenarios will leave residents with limited employment options, declining service levels, increasing vacant properties, and increasing social isolation.

In addition, there are three important aspects of the future quality of life for residents of Gort:

- Digital technology will continue to be an important influence in work, service and social participation irrespective of the future scenarios
- Population diversity will continue to be a unique quality of Gort. Whether residents feel included and integrated within the community of Gort depends on how well it is supported and should be an ongoing concern for both scenarios.
- Quality of life for residents in the future will be determined far less by individual projects and more by either the coordination of all implemented projects or the inclusion of all Gort residents.

These findings suggest that residents' well-being is strongly linked to how evenly opportunities are distributed and sustained over time.

5.9 Risks and Opportunities Across Scenarios

Key Opportunities

- Effective governance enables all areas of digital development, regeneration, and social investment to complement each other.
- Inclusive digital transformation allows for increased widespread access to skills and employment, better access to services, and enhanced economic resilience.
- The regeneration of town centers may provide the basis for increased trust and engagement within communities and increase the viability of businesses.

Risks

- Digital adoption is not evenly distributed and may deepen inequality if there are insufficient supportive services and adequate skill sets available.
- Out-migration of youth from communities and declining populations reduces the number of students enrolled, thereby threatening the viability of schools, services, and businesses.
- High rates of vacancy and economic decline in town centres may indicate a serious structural weakness.

The patterns suggest that all scenarios will contain elements of digital change, population trends and town centre vitality. However, the difference is that these elements may be considered either assets or vulnerabilities depending on the scenario.

5.10 Implications for Policymakers

The cross-scenario analysis has shown that the most influential factor shaping the outcomes is the governance capacity. All of the scenarios have demonstrated that increased investment through strong coordination will yield a greater return compared to poorly coordinated investment decisions limiting potential.

Major Implications for policymakers are:

- **Governance is more important than any investment:** Governance can provide support through coordination, investment capabilities and long-term planning. Good governance will outperform investing in a project that is not governed in the right manner.
- **Digital infrastructure is not enough:** It is important to develop the capability of people to use the digital infrastructure and to include as many people as possible.

- **Timing is crucial:** The sooner coordinated actions are taken, the more future options are preserved. As the time continues to pass, this option becomes narrower and the cost increases.
- **Youth opportunities are economic foundations:** Education, community infrastructure and providing opportunities to youth are the building blocks of economic resilience. Therefore, even with a negative economic forecast, these three factors will remain vital.
- **Town Centre Vitality is strategic:** It is a reflection of the overall health of the broader system rather than simple cosmetic improvements.

6. Strategic Recommendations

The following recommendations are proposed for policymakers and stakeholders based on the scenario analysis:

Strengthening local governance through coordination, collaboration and long-term planning. By creating a strong local governance structure, it maximises the impact of future investments. (Department of Rural and Community Development, 2021)

Supporting the development of digital skills for both residents and businesses, as well as making sure that all residents can access digital services, helps in development. The ability to develop digital skills and gain access to digital services determines if there is an increase or decrease in the digital divide or disparity amongst various demographic groups (Government of Ireland, 2021).

Focusing on the reuse of vacant buildings, mixed-use developments and improvements to the public realm. Town centres' vitality are indicative of a strong economic and social support system for surrounding areas (Gort – Town Centre First, 2022)

Investing in providing services for youth and community places develops a vibrant social life, provides opportunities for cultural enrichment, and creates pathways for students to connect to jobs.

Expanding remote working, tourism and housing gradually in line with demand. Incremental growth reduces the chance of overcommitting to high-risk investments or making poor decisions based on uncertainty.

Conduct regular reviews of emerging trends and make necessary alterations to strategy so as to respond to the shifting conditions of the environment. A flexible approach will better ensure resilience to the unknowns of the future.

7. Conclusions

To conclude, this report summarises that Gort's long-term future will be shaped by choices made in the present. With the use of foresight techniques such a horizon scanning and drivers mapping, three plausible future scenarios for 2060 were explored. Across all scenarios Governance Quality, Digital Inclusion, Social Cohesion, and Town Centre Vitality were decisive factors. Early, coordinated and action can transform digitalisation, cultural diversity and town-centre regeneration into strengths that enhance quality of life. Conversely, fragmented decision-making risks long-term decline. Overall, the pathway to greater resilience is through the use of foresight to direct future strategic choices. Decision-makers who use foresight can better navigate uncertainty because they can choose to influence the ongoing issues into strengths, rather than sources for decline.

AI Declaration

Generative AI tools were used in accordance with DCU Business School guidelines to support outlining, language refinement, grammar checking and formatting.

No substantive ideas, analysis, interpretations, or conclusions were generated by AI.
All arguments, scenario logic, and final expressions reflect our own original thought and judgement.

References

Town Centre First Policy (2022) *gov.ie*. Available at: https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-rural-and-community-development-and-the-gaeltacht/publications/town-centre-first-policy/ (Accessed: 1 December 2025).

Rural Regeneration & Development Projects (2025) *Donegal County Council*. Available at: https://www.donegalcoco.ie/en/services/planning/regeneration-and-development/project-updates/rural-regeneration-development-projects (Accessed: 16 December 2025).

Gort labour catchment analysis – Travel to Work and Labour Catchments in the Western Region. Western Development Commission & CSO POWCAR. Available at: https://westerndevelopment.ie/ (Accessed: 1 December 2025).

Travel to Work and Labour Catchments in the Western Region – Census 2022 Data. WDC, published 19 September. Available at: https://westerndevelopment.ie/publications/travel-to-work-and-labour-catchments-in-the-western-region-census-2022/ (Accessed: 1 December 2025).

Local Government Ireland (2025) *Town Centre First.* Available at: https://www.localgov.ie/national-programmes/town-centre-first?utm_source (Accessed: 14 December 2025).

Urban Initiative (2024) *Ireland's Town Centre First.* Available at: https://www.urban-initiative.eu/news/irelands-town-centre-first?utm_ (Accessed: 14 December 2025).

Curry, A. *et al.* "Intelligent Infrastructure Futures The Scenarios – Towards 2055."

The Futures Toolkit: Tools for Futures Thinking and Foresight Across UK Government Resource (2017). Available at: https://embeddingproject.org/resources/the-futures-toolkit-tools-for-futures-thinking-and-foresight-across-uk-government/ (Accessed: December 17, 2025).

Draft Gort Local Area Plan 2025-2031 | Galway County Council Online Consultation Portal (2025). Available at: https://consult.galway.ie/en/consultation/draft-gort-local-area-plan-2025-2031 (Accessed: December 10 2025).

Department of Finance. (2025). Ireland's Demographic Outlook: Trends and Scenarios for the Next Forty Years. Available at: https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-finance/publications/future-forty-irelands-demographic-outlook (Accessed: December 1 2025).

Galway County Council. (2023). Gort: Town Centre First – Need and Project Identification and Justification Report.

Lynn, T., Fox, J., Curran, D., Hynes, K., O'Gorman, C., & Rosati, P. (2023). *Digital Town Blueprint: 2023 Town Report – Gort, Co. Galway*.